

Migrant Settlement and Gentrification in Footscray

Residential patterns of migration in inner western Melbourne

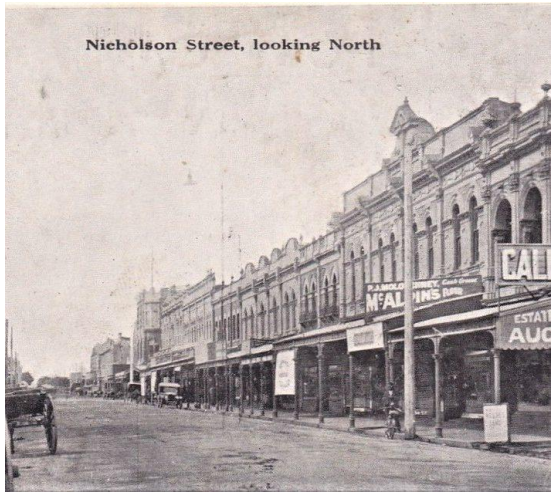
Ryan O'Grady | SOC20013 Race, Ethnicity and Migration

Why Footscray?

- For decades, it was a popular first stop for new migrants – a gateway suburb (Easthope et al., 2018)
- Cheap housing, nearby work, existing community
- Urban renewal projects are pricing out that role
- The gateway is moving further west



Back in the day...



1880s-1960s

Factories, then Italian, Greek, Maltese, Yugoslav workers



1975+

Vietnamese refugees settle around Hopkins St



1990s+

Horn of Africa communities, Nicholson St



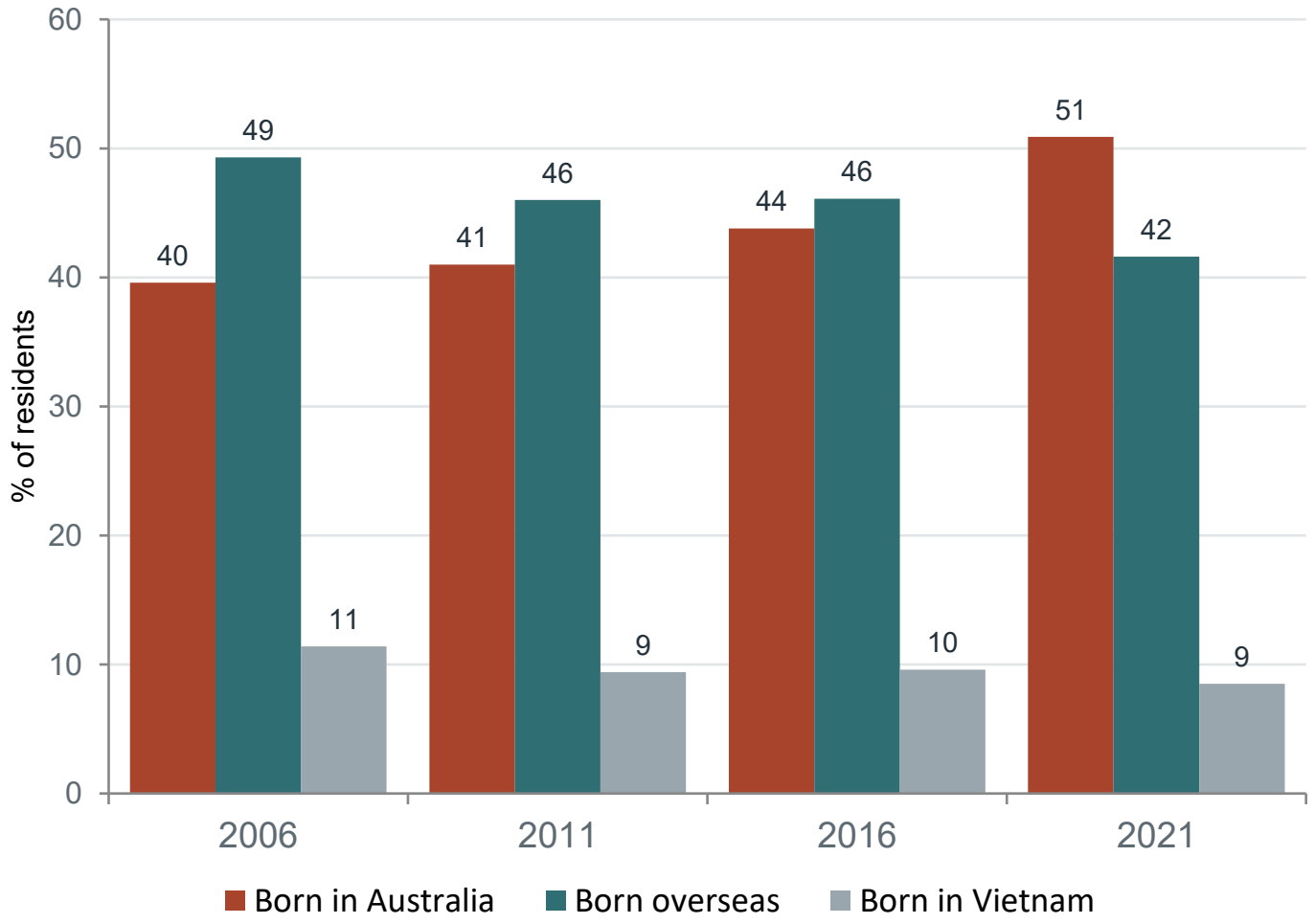
2010s+

Factories cleared for apartments

"By 1996 one-half of the population had been born overseas" (Lack, 2008)

Lack (2008); Hugo (2011); Lemma & Spark (2024)

Who lives in Footscray now?



- Overseas-born share falling since 2016
- Vietnamese community is aging in place with 60% aged 45+
- New arrivals are generally younger; 87% of Indian migrants aged 15-44

Australian Bureau of Statistics (2007, 2012, 2017, 2022)



Since the last census (2021-2026)

+20%

residents, 2021–2025 (17,419 → 20,882); about double Melbourne's average rate

1,758

new dwellings approved since July 2021; 98% are high-rise/apartments or townhouses (only 31 were detached houses)

+44%

median weekly rent, 2021-2025 ($365 → $525)

52.3%

of dwellings were flats or apartments in 2021 (32.7% in 2006)

Australian Bureau of Statistics (2022, 2026a, 2026b); Department of Families, Fairness and Housing (2025)

Why Footscray became a gateway

- Cheap housing near factory jobs and a migrant hostel
- Chain migration - newcomers follow family and compatriots
- Enough people to keep ethnic shops and services viable

> *“For me, Footscray resembles home.”*
>
> Ethiopian woman interviewed in Footscray (Lemma & Spark, 2024, p. 440)

Dunn (1998); Hugo (2011); Lemma & Spark (2024)





Why migrants are now moving further west

- Government-planned renewal: activity centre since 2002
- Rents rising faster than the outer west
- Owners stay; renters “residualised in place”
- Vietnamese generally own their shop locations; African shopkeepers mostly rent
- Ethiopian, Somali communities now mostly further west

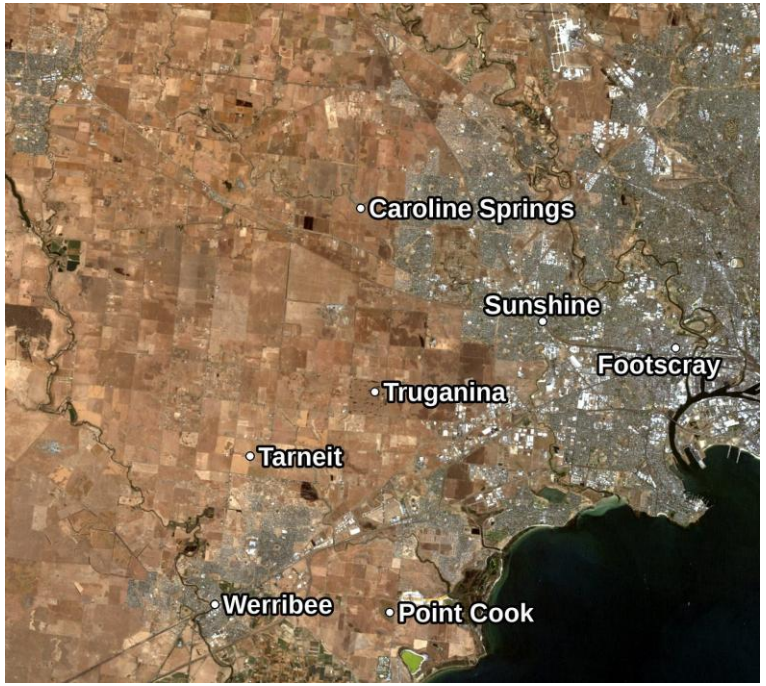
Migrant populations “moved further west due to the inability to afford the cost of living in this inner-city suburb”

Lemma & Spark (2024, p. 438)



Maribyrnong City Council (2026); Easthope et al. (2018); McConville & Oke (2018); Victorian Government (n.d.-a, n.d.-b)

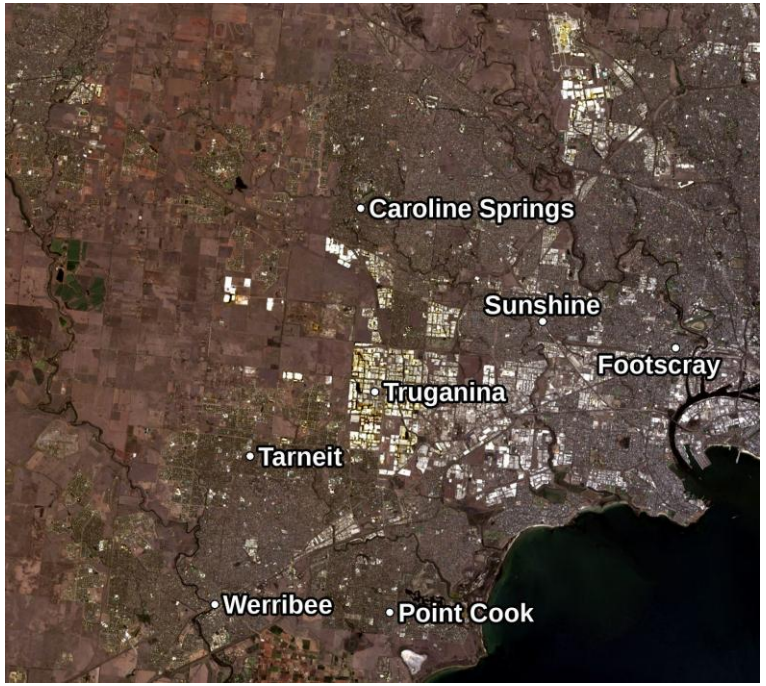
Where did everyone go?



1991 Tarneit, Truganina, Point Cook and Caroline Springs are paddocks



2006 Caroline Springs and Point Cook built; Tarneit still farmland



2025 Housing and warehouses now fill Tarneit and Truganina

Ethiopian and Somali Victorians now live mostly in Wyndham, Brimbank and Hume

Victorian Government (n.d.-a, n.d.-b)

Not just ethnicity but class

Concept	What it says	In Footscray
Spatial assimilation	Enclaves are “transitory phenomena” (Forrest et al., 2006, p. 441)	Vietnamese residents aging in place; children move out
Invasion-0succession	A new group moves in and replaces the old	Footscray “fits within the first stages” (McConville & Oke, 2018, p. 133)
Race as class	“Does money whiten?” (Gans, 2005)	Income now decides who can move in
Skilled vs refugee	Skilled migrants choose by “socioeconomic rather than ethnic factors” (Hugo, 2011, p. 24)	Students and professionals in; low-income arrivals further west

Gentrification is a “state and market-driven ‘class remake’ of cities” (Shaw, 2008, p. 1697)



Footscray in the news

2016 Little Saigon Market destroyed by fire

2017 Hipster cafes vandalised

2026 Residents ask council for “more affordable housing”

“Footscray's newest residents are younger, whiter and more likely to work in white-collar jobs”

Costello (2017), SBS News

ABC News (2016); McConville & Oke (2018); Maribyrnong City Council (2026, p. 16)

Missing from current policy

1 **Affordable housing in new towers**

not only for “key workers”

2 **Secure leases for migrant traders**

short leases leave African shops exposed

3 **Settlement services further west**

where arrivals now live: Wyndham, Brimbank, Hume

4 **Recent arrivals in planning decisions**

not just established groups



Maribyrnong City Council (2026); McConville & Oke (2018); Easthope et al. (2018); Dekker & Mullan (2021)

Conclusion

1. Footscray was a gateway because it was cheap, close to work and had an established community
2. Urban renewal, gentrification and increased rents have priced that role out
3. New policy should accommodate the new arrivals, not just existing groups

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